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Thomas Aquinas in Context

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On the Discursive Intellect's Use of Phantasms in Aquinas's Theory of Cognition

In Aquinas's account of sublunar creation, living beings accord to a gradation of powers marked by distinctive tiers of achievement. This hierarchy can be said to reflect increasingly sophisticated capacities of living beings for integrating their surroundings within their own being. Where vegetative life is defined by a capacity for the physical ingestion and appropriation of its surroundings, animal life is defined by a capacity for sense reception, enabling various impressions of surroundings to be aggregated as an internal resemblance and navigated as such. Human life signals a radical advance. In stepping from merely collating repeated impressions to professing universal determinations (including the determination of his own immaterial soul) man demonstrates a new and conscious awareness of beings and causal structures extending beyond those perceptible in the corporeal world, an awareness that implies the simultaneous advent of a corresponding immaterial faculty. It is evident, however, that this immaterial recognition of immaterial being relies on continued access to corporeally-founded sense-impressions of corporeal beings (*ST* 1a 84.7 23-43). Aquinas takes these respective facts (man's ability to perceive universals and man's dependence on phantasms) to mean that man's intellect is not such that it is able to simply direct its attention toward an object and thereby understand it immediately in its full essence. Rather, in order to define initially vague objects of understanding, the human intellect must marshal existing determinations ("words"), themselves linking to retained sense-impressions, in the way that several small mirrored surfaces can be angled to bring together disparately located objects onto a single surface as a single image. This internal process eventually achieves an understanding in which the object is itself determined and ordered to an existing conceptual manifold (85.5 29-31; 85.6 30-33), and it is in this way that man integrates his immaterial surroundings within himself. In order to clarify this human project of reconciling immaterial order using material impressions, my approach will be (1) to establish the relational dynamics between the corporeal-sensory and the immaterial-intellectual powers and (2) in the terms of this dualistic apparatus, to account for the discursive intellectual process with its peculiar engine of shifting emphasis between synchronous and sequential consideration of parts. This serves, ultimately, as a description of the mechanisms by which man attempts to align his being, as much as is naturally possible, with the being of God.

1.

Our initial task is to establish the workings of the human perceptual apparatus. Although man's sense powers are ultimately shaped by his intellective capacity, the human-being and the brute animal share the same fundamental sensory design (*ST* 1a 78.4 90-2). My approach will be to first establish the sensory powers at this animal level so that the ensuing influence of the intellect upon these powers can most clearly be seen.

The external senses are passive capacities attuned to respective media of corporeal activity. Through them, the animal is able to receive impressions not only in a “natural” sense, affecting its being as a corporeal thing (as the fire's heat affects the body), but also in a “spiritual” sense, as somehow permeating its being or leaving an impression within its being (as the fire's light streams *through* the pupil) (78.3 47-53). The receptions of the various senses are conveyed to a *common sense* responsible for reconciling them, discerning further impressions revealed in their aggregate (motion, size, etc) and also of discerning *that* it is sensing (78.4 ad. 2 126-135). Such impressions do not disperse straightaway but must be retained to some extent in all complete animals. The power of retention and preservation is the *imagination*, which serves as "a kind of treasury for forms grasped through the senses" (78.4 80-83). The impressions assembled by the common sense are prone to error; that is, they may not indeed correspond to present surroundings (*OnDA* 664). Imagination is just the positive application of this phantasmic residue of non-correspondence for bringing absent sensible things to a limited kind of presence (78.4 50-53). When the animal encounters a situation consistent with one being retained it assembles, or associates its occurrence with, a previously experienced consequence. Nearby vibration, for example, may be associated with the presence of prey. Yet, to the extent that this association does not in fact correspond to the surrounding concrete situation, but is only a probable outcome, it is phantasmic. The vibration may turn out to be the wind. In this way, the imagination, drawing on the animal's repeated encounters with its surroundings, begins to allow the animal to orient within a generally accurate apprehension of those surroundings.

Beyond learning by repetition, which only serves to account for the animal's ability to acquire what is pleasurable to its senses over an extended duration of time, animals also evidence deference to some principle responsible for orienting them, regardless of learning, toward their benefit or utility (as the sheep has an innate tendency to fear the wolf, and the bird to gather straw for nest-making) (78.4 94-95). Such intentions, which apply to all animals among a species, must be understood to derive from "a kind of natural instinct", or "a sort of custom" (79.4 95; 1a2ae 50.3 ad. 2). The animal, according to the nature of its species, comes pre-clothed, as it were, in a given configuration of qualities (its "disposition"). This consideration, then, suggests a further pair of powers: a *power of comparison* (mere "estimation" in animals) which reconciles the impressions housed in the imagination, orienting toward its pleasure, with the animal's natural behavioural tendencies with respect to these impressions, orienting toward its benefit or utility. These modified intentions are preserved, finally, in a second treasury, the *memory*, which functions to augment the imagination's capacity for orientating the animal's pursuits according to an inner microcosm of causal associations.

Now, in animals having a certain advanced natural disposition – namely, human-beings (1a2ae 51.1) – the process does not stop there. As with imagination, memory, through repetition of similar encounters, or "experience", has a generalizing tendency (*InAPo* 2.20). The tendency, however, only reaches a terminus with the advent of the intellect. Aquinas raises the famous example from *Metaphysics* I.1:

> [F]rom many particulars in which it has been experienced, it takes one common item which is consolidated in the mind and considers it without considering any of the singulars. This common item reason takes as a principle of art and science. For example, as long as a doctor considered that this herb cured Socrates of fever, and Plato and many other individual men, it is *experience*; but when his considerations arise to the fact that such a species of herb heals a fever absolutely, this is taken as a *rule of the art of medicine*. (*ibid.*)

The advent of the intellect is *just this leap* from the capacity to consolidate *some number of particulars* to the capacity to consider *their common principle as universally true*. This is the operation Aquinas terms abstraction: "to cognize that which is in individual matter, *not as it is in such matter*" (85.1 53-55, emphasis added). It is only with this transformation that the progressive "spiritual" dematerialization of the corporeal object begun by the senses is fulfilled.

The intellect's ability to comprehend forms entirely divorced from their matter means that it must exist and apprehend at a different ontological order than the body and its organs. When at-work, then, the intellective capacity represents the having-been-generated of a higher order of spiritual existence (universal, immaterial) from out of the same being, and so suggests powers facilitating ontological elevation (79.2). The ability to abstract from bodily impressions, then, requires two new powers which perform the respective functions of *abstracting* the common species (this is the role of the *agent intellect*), and *assimilating* to its object at the level of immaterial universal being (the *possible intellect*) (79.7 30-37).

This intellectual leap corresponds with several other developments. The disposition for intellection is identical with the disposition for the apprehension of first principles (79.9 50-51), and perhaps especially "the firmest and most certain principle", that of non-contradiction: "it is impossible for the same attribute both to belong and not belong to the same subject at the same time" (*InMeta* 599). This is the recognition that something either *is* in a certain state in a given respect or *is not*, thereby opening the vast project of the precise determination of things. It is characteristic of such determinations that, as they are acquired, the imply certain others, of necessity, in turn; in this way, the basic product of the highly primary principle of intellection is the capacity for syllogistic, or deductive, reasoning. By taking one thing (namely, a single predicate of a single subject) and comparing it to another related by a common term, a third thing follows out of necessity. This method can be applied cumulatively and systematically to the various sectors of human experience.[1]

This deployment of the syllogism which follows upon the recognition of first principles which *just are* the intellect allows for the distinguishing of *causes* from out of their *effects*. This distinguishing can occur in three ways, which Aquinas describes at *SCG* III.49.3. In the most resolved case (hereby α), as in the sciences, one sees the effect and the cause set apart as two things. In the subsequent cases the distinction is less clean. In the second way (hereby β), the cause is seen *in* the effect, superimposed as it were, "according as the likeness of the cause is reflected in the effect" in the way a man (cause) is seen in a mirror in virtue of the display of his likeness in it (effect). In this way of knowing a cause, the effects out of which it is discerned are experienced as transparent, unnoticed, or implicit. In the third

1 This results in the widespread organization of things according to *genus and species* when the intellect deduces with a view to what is in common or different between abstracted things (*InAPo* 2.20). While Aquinas has termed "intellection" the disposition and activity that grasps the first principles necessary for *performing* these derivations, he terms the *achievement* of such derivations according to their dimension of influence within this manifold (whether "science", "wisdom", "practical" or "habitual") (1a2ae 57.2).

way (hereby γ), the effects through which the cause is discerned are somehow used "such that the very likeness of the cause, in its effect, is the form by which the effect knows its own cause", in the way that a "box [having] an intellect" could ascertain causes based on its own formal characteristics as an effect.[2] To put the third way in the terms of the second, it would be to notice or otherwise use the mirror likeness (effect) in order to be able to more sharply distinguish the man (cause) enabling it. The third way, then, is complementary with the second. To the extent that the effects (experienced as unnoticed, transparent, or implicit) out of which the cause is discerned formalize the appearance of that cause, these effects themselves can be identified as sorts of causes, capable of being discerned.[3]

The third way of distinguishing is especially at play in man's ability to notice aspects of his own perceptual apparatus, which follows upon the mere presence of the intellect (87.1 69-71). Man's intellect, since it only "actually" comes into being when it is *thinking some thing*, is hidden in its object (87.3 30-40). Man's ability to "bend back" toward his own apparatus despite this, as an ordinary matter of course, is the result of being able to shift from an awareness in the sense β, above, to one in the sense γ, above,[4] by some sort of deductive inference.

The reflective capacity can help to understand the intellect's ongoing parallel relation to the sensory apparatus. As we know, the immaterial intellect must maintain continuous access to sensory phantasms in order to function:

> even after [our intellect] has abstracted intellectual species, it cannot actually understand through them except by turning toward phantasms, in which it understands the intelligible species, as is said in *De Anima* III. In this way, then, it directly understands the universal itself

2 We can better understand Aquinas's analogy here by his discussion at *SCG* I.76.2, in which he elaborates the thesis that formalizing principles (e.g. light) are perceived in the same act as the intentional object (e.g. colour) that they formalize.

3 My discussion here, which can only be highly compressed, attempts to follow the controversial recent interpretation of implicit cognition and reflection in Aquinas forwarded by Scarpelli Cory in *Aquinas on Human Self-Knowledge* (2015). Cory differentiates between implicit and explicit reflection in Aquinas, which the human-being can shift between without disrupting the species under consideration. See especially Ch. 5 and p140, "the principle thesis".

4 This describes our ordinary experience of drawing out of what feels like a primary narrative of our day (this person, this conversation) into a reflective meta-narrative ("why is he looking at me strangely? Did I say something rude?").

> through an intelligible species, whereas it indirectly understands the singulars that the phantasms concern. (86.1 20-29)

The actualization of the intellect is just the abstraction of and assimilation to the common consideration from some number of phantasms. So while their common object is being understood *in* and *through* them in the "direct" sense of causes in way β, the phantasms are understood only in the "indirect" constitutive sense of effects in way β. The singular phantasms, however, as aspects of the perceptual apparatus, may themselves be turned to, insofar as they themselves are causes in the sense γ, "through a kind of reflection" which attempts to isolate their influence.

The altogether structure begins to come into view. So long as he is conscious, man is the animal that transforms the sense-impressions that stream through his sense receptors up to immaterial actuality. The intellect erupts out of phantasms sedimenting in the memory, and entails the development of a closely-knit cluster of capacities: for considering some number of particulars according to their common principles, for recognizing the principle of non-contradiction, for making deductions, and for reflecting upon formative principles. This achievement, in turn, "spills over", back to the late-stage sense powers (78.4 ad. 5). When the intellect, having made distinctions, turns back to those powers, they are used and conditioned according to those distinctions. While brute animals only "estimate" according to their instinct and have their remembrances bound-up with their future-oriented pursuits of pleasure, in humans the comparing power ("cogitative power") becomes adapted to the methods of precise measurement, and the memory becomes ordered by continuous syllogistic retrievals (78.4 97-105). This new utilization of retained sensory phantasms results in a thinking experience that is at once intellective and affective, emergent upon and co-existent with a continuing influx of presently surrounding corporeal sensations.

2.

The purpose of the outlining of the perceptual apparatus has been to set the stage for an explication of the intellectual *process* (the discursive intellect). In broad strokes, the process occurs as follows. When the agent facilitates the consideration of a thing (preserved in sensory phantasms) apart from its matter ("abstracts"), the assimilation or actualization of the possible intellect does not happen straightaway except with regard to the first principles the dispositional presence of which *just are* the intellective capacity. First, following a "simple and unconditioned" abstraction from phantasms, the possible intellect assimilates to a highly generalized grasp of the immaterial object (its quiddity). Then begins the discursive process when, in a similitude of generative motion, this initial understanding of a whole is "composed and divided" from its surroundings (*ST* 1a 85.5 29-32; 85.1 ad. 1 65-67). Finally, definition is achieved, forming an internal "word" (*InJohn* I.1 55-58).

Let us trace this process more closely before attempting to define it with precision. We must begin with a digression on the role of the dispositions and habits. As discussed above, an animal's natural disposition is the default calibration of qualities characteristic of its species, modifying the animal's interpretation of phantasms. Man has dispositions not only in this relatively quantitative sense, located as it is in a bodily organ of a composite being, but also in the intellect alone (79.6 ad. 1). Intellective dispositions are learnable universal determinations. Once learned, they are "habits", existing potentially, ready to be actualized on command. They are preserved in the possible intellect as an intellectual analogue to memory (79.6; 1a2ae 50.4 ad. 1). We then have two sites of preservation of species in the human being: sensory species, in the memory, bearing the modifications of the dispositions; and intellectual species, in the possible intellect, following the application of first principles. The memory and the habits, as such sites, assist their bearer in acquiring the objects of their desire by adapting them to a generally accurate semblance of their surroundings. The habits, full of "words", constitute an immaterial manifold of *definitions* which each corresponding to a given configuration of remembered sensory *affects*.[5] So, when the possible intellect, potentially assimilated to anything, begins the discursive process, it is not, as it were, against an empty background. The definitions that it derives must negotiate existing frameworks of definitions and experiences. How this occurs is yet unclear.

When a quiddity is first apprehended, the abstraction is "simple and unconditioned" and the assimilation to the object is at its "most general and confused" (85.3 29-31). "Confusion", for Aquinas, has a technical meaning: those things "which contain in themselves something potential and indistinct" (*InPhys* I.8). For a quiddity to be utterly confused with its surroundings is for the intellect to grasp its existence as some thing (whatever it may be) but have yet to have actualized it with any specificity. The intellect "then" considers the things surrounding the thing's essence (85.5 29-33; 85.6 30-33). In order for the intellect to be able to consider multiple things at once it must think them under their common "difference or relationship", as parts under a single whole (85.5 ad. 1; 85.4 ad. 4). It seems then that the first stage of abstraction consists of the first coming into focus of the various things associated with the object of thought.

The next stage is of "composition and division": the attempt to discern the quiddity with definition, i.e., to separate out its essence. To provide a provisional description: the intellect does this by somehow matching the collection of things to existing definitions in the soul (internal "words") to form "a statement or something of that sort" (85.2 ad. 3 113-117; *InJohn* I.1 29-34). This statement functions as a body of propositions. Each proposition asserts that a subject belongs a predicate, before such an assertion is somehow "judged" to conform or not with surrounding reality (*ST* 1a 16.2). The results of such propositions can be built on one another until the syllogistic process refines the quiddity into an essential definition distinguished from its surroundings, itself becoming a new "word" available

5 At least, to the extent that the words reference universal definitions of corporeal objects. The human intellect can cognize immaterial substances, but only through methods of adding and subtracting and comparisons to material things, which it tends to understand as causes (84.7 ad. 3). This being so, some "words" may reference causal structures in the habits, themselves subtractions of material things, and so have highly limited affective correspondence.

to the soul (*InJohn* I.1 80-85).

The central difficulty of composition and division is the interchange of *synchronous* and *successive* consideration it entails. Synchronous, because the various things composed and divided must exist under a common aspect, and "whatever an intellect can think about under a single species, it can think about at the same time..." (85.4). Successive, because deduction (syllogizing) implies exclusive considerations, which must occur in a causal succession: "everyone reasoning sees the principle by one consideration and the conclusions by another. There would be no need to proceed to conclusions after the consideration of the principles if by considering the principles we also considered the conclusions" (*SCG* I.57.3). How can these two apparently contradictory features be reconciled?

The limits of this dilemma are provided by *ST* 1a 85.4 ad. 3:

> Parts can be thought of in two ways. First, under some confusion, as they are in the whole, and in this way they are cognized through a single form of the whole, and so are cognized at the same time. Second, by a distinct cognition, inasmuch as each is cognized through its own species. In this way they are not thought of at the same time.

To the extent that the parts are conceived as existing under a whole, they are seen simultaneously but "under some confusion". To the extent that any single part is thought distinctly, the unity of the original whole is broken; the "species" under consideration has changed and the thought is of something else. The parts under consideration during a discursive process, then, can neither be thought entirely synchronously, nor so distinctly that their common aspect is dissolved.

Two passages suggest the way the discursive rhythm may occur within these limits. In *ST* 1a 14.7, Aquinas distinguishes two modes of discursion: the first is "as when we have actually understood anything, we turn ourselves to understand something else", and the second is "as when through principles we arrive at [knowledge]". The former mode represents a shift from one thing considered in itself to another thing considered in itself, as is typical of a cognitive shift from one species to another. The latter mode, which Aquinas identifies with discursive reasoning, "*presupposes the first mode*" (emphasis added), insofar as the procession from principles to conclusions requires a sequence of thought (first *this*, then *that*). This discursion only ceases upon the "resolving the effects into their causes".

Second, in *ST* 1a 79.8, Aquinas makes an analogy between the intellective process ("reasoning") and movement, and "because motion always advances from something immovable and stops at some resting point, so it is that human reasoning, in the course of investigation and discovery, advances from certain things that are grasped directly by the intellect... [t]hen, in the course of judgement, it returns by analysis to those first principles, and relative to these it examines its discoveries", with "judgement" meaning: "an act of intellect that applies principles that are certain to an examination of the things proposed" (79.9 ad. 4).

The discursive pattern suggested in each passage is, first, causal-successive (*this* then *that*) and then synchronous (*this*-and-*that*), resolving the former into the latter, as a way of consolidating knowledge and climbing ever closer to an altogether resolution. This is the basic rhythm of the syllogism. Given the pattern suggested here and the limits of the dilemma given above, I propose the following account of the discursive process.

First, the agent intellect abstracts from sensory phantasms, modified by the disposition, retained in the memory. The initial abstraction is most simple, unconditioned, general, and confused. It is as if the intellect has encircled the variety of things corresponding to the quiddity it perceives, and has just begun to consider them collectively, apart from their matter, but has not yet drawn them into any proportion. While such phantasms are part of the constitutive basis of the intellection, and in this sense the intellect is already "turned" toward them (as implicit effects in the sense β), the possible intellect has not yet assimilated to their immaterial form. From this point forward, the intellectual species under consideration – with just these parts – may not change without disrupting the unity of the thought.

“Secondly”, says Aquinas, “it forms either a *definition* or a *division or composition*” (85.2 ad. 3 113-116, emphasis added). This seems to suggest that if an existing definition (or “internal word”) is available – to the extent that the species under consideration is already habitually known – the possible intellect will be straightforwardly assimilated to it (and this service as a ready manifold of understanding seems to be just the function of the habits). Now, perhaps some or indeed all of the parts grasped along with the quiddity are known but not in their collective significance. In this case, it seems that those known would be actualized in the confused sense belonging to parts considered under a more primary common whole, and a “division or composition” (or “statement”) would be formed containing various parts more or less already actualized.

Next begins the process of composition and division. Building up from what has already been established in mind according to the first principles of the intellect, the agent and possible intellect begin the sequential-sychronous rhythm, characteristic of the syllogistic process, oriented at resolving the statement under consideration. This presents a difficulty according to the limitation that the intellectual species under consideration must not have any of its parts be given distinct consideration: how can they, then, be considered sequentially, to the exclusion of the other parts under consideration? I propose the following solution. From beginning to end of the consideration, the intellect must be turned toward the phantasms in the sense the they persist in an implicit constitutive role (sense β, earlier). The intentional object does not change.[6] At points where emphasis (*this* or *that*) is required,

6 Scarpelli Cory on this point: “[T]he intentionality of a given intellectual act is governed by two principles, both of which sometimes go under the name 'intention': the species being *used* (which specifies a range of intelligible content), and the *direction* of the intellectual attention (which determines the intellect to *some aspect* of the intelligibility made present via the species. A single species-intention can support many attention-intentions, like a multipurpose instrument. For instance, one might think of a man as rational, teachable, living, mammalian, in distinct acts, all using a single species of man... In short, the range of thoughts that I can have is delimited by the species I use, but *what I think about within that specified range* (the-object-under-a-specific-aspect) is determined by how I choose to direct my attention” (164).

however, the intellect may give special attention to given “words” and correspondent phantasms by shifting them into explicit reflective consideration (sense γ, earlier). These parts are given special attention insofar as they are *noticed* in their likenesses among the rest of the collection. The agent intellect and possible intellect function something like a rotating assembly, drawing to focus now *this* and now *that* section of a build, but without ever dropping the altogether collection of parts.

As the syllogistic process continues, propositions are progressively resolved. The propositions the intellect is concerned with are precisely those in disparity with the existing habitual manifold. The parts under consideration surround a yet undiscerned definition (essence). In order to arrive at a definition, the intellect must reconcile this collection with the existing body of words in the habits. By the continual deployment of syllogisms,[7] the intellect resolves the disparity between the various parts under consideration and the habitual manifold, until they reach alignment, and the hitherto unfamiliar thing is adjusted for by this manifold and set into its proper place.

Through this discursive process, man continually develops an interconnected set of determinations in the intellectual memory (habits) which conforms, more or less accurately, to the surrounding immaterial order he is able to discern. This arrangement shapes his internal resemblance of the surrounding material order retained in the memory, which in turn modulate the phantasms that condition man's responses to his immediate surroundings. Unlike God, the resemblance man builds can only ever be piecemeal, expressible only intermittently and through multiple incomplete words (*InJohn* I.1.93-106). The extent to which man is successful in developing such a resemblance in his own soul is the extent to which he rises to the limits of natural reason and natural happiness.

7 A thorough discussion of this process would depend on an analysis of Aquinas's commentary on the *Posterior Analytics*.